



# Build Your Own Skew Map — How to See What Options Traders Are Actually Paying For (and the Weekend Version You Can Build Yourself) (1)

Price tells you what a stock did. The options chain tells you what people are paying to be protected from what it does next. That gap is the whole map — here's how to read it, the five traps that make most people read it backwards, and how to build a working version yourself over a weekend.

By [berttrading](#) — a swing trader sharing how I research, not an advisor.

*Educational only. Nothing here is financial advice or a recommendation to buy or sell any stock. This is a positioning layer — where to look — not a signal and not a buy list. Do your own research and manage your own risk.*

🕒 **How this is laid out.** Parts 1–3 are **the read** — what skew is, the four quadrants, and the five mistakes that make most people read it backwards. Ten minutes, and it's useful on its own even if you never build anything. Parts 4–6 are **the build**: a spreadsheet you can stand up in an afternoon and run in 15–20 minutes a week. Part 7 onward is what the finished version looks like once it's running.

**If you read one section, make it Part 2.** That's the entire framework in one table.

*Every screenshot here is a single day's board. The numbers on it moved the next morning — that's the point of a daily map. What doesn't move is how you read it, which is what the rest of this page is about.*

I run a skew map every afternoon. It scores a few hundred names on what the options market is charging for downside protection versus upside, cross-references that against how the stock actually traded, and sorts everything into four buckets. It takes about twelve seconds to run and it took me two weeks and one genuinely embarrassing bug to get right.

What you need isn't my version — it's the **read**, and a simple version you can actually maintain. You can build one with your broker's option chain, any free screener, and a spreadsheet.

This is mine, from the close on August 17. Top strip first — where money moved, and which sector is paying most for protection:

|                                                                                |                                                                              |                                                                               |                                                                    |                                                                     |                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| S&P 500 (SPY), 1 month<br><b>+4.0%</b><br>QQQ +5.0% · IWM +3.4% ·<br>RSP +3.5% | Money moved in<br><b>Cons Disc</b><br>turnover share +33.4 bps ·<br>1M +0.5% | Money moved out<br><b>Info Tech</b><br>turnover share -154 bps ·<br>1M +14.9% | Steepest sector skew<br><b>Utilities</b><br>5.3% weighted 25Δ skew | Flattest sector skew<br><b>Comm Svcs</b><br>-3.3% — calls in demand | Index skew (SPY)<br><b>30.7%</b><br>QQQ 22.8% · IWM 28.5% —<br>index > single names |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

*Read it left to right: money in, money out, most-hedged sector. The thing to look for isn't the biggest number — it's a sector where dollars are leaving while the price is still rising. Flow and price disagreeing is the whole reason this strip sits at the top instead of a return column.*

Then the written read:

Auto-written from the numbers below, same rules every day. Every claim can be checked in the sortable table underneath.

- The tape: **SPY** -0.5% today (+4.0% on the month) · **QQQ** -0.2% · small caps (IWM) -0.3% · volatility (VXX) +0.7% → **mixed — no strong signal from volatility.**
- **Gold / silver miners** is the strongest theme in the market — +27.3% vs SPY over a month, with 100% of its names participating. Broad moves like this are the healthy kind. Names: NEM, HL, CDE
- **Software** is leading but losing steam — still up big on the month, fading right now. If you're long it, protect gains before adding. — that means MSFT, PLTR, ORCL.
- **Health tech / GLP1** stays in the penalty box — weak month, no bounce yet, nothing to do until buyers actually show up (that includes LLY, UNH, ISRG).
- Caution flag on the watchlist: **IONQ** keeps rallying while someone pays heavily for crash protection underneath (skew 54.0%). If you're long, tighten stops — that's insurance buying, not enthusiasm.
- Big-picture tide: real trading dollars moved toward **Cons Disc** this month (+33.4 bps of the entire market's volume).

*Written from the numbers underneath, same rules every day — so a quiet day reads quiet and I can't talk myself into anything. The sentence type worth waiting for is the caution flag — a name that keeps rallying while someone underneath it pays heavily for crash protection. A stock going up while somebody buys expensive insurance on it isn't enthusiasm, it's hedging, and it means tighten rather than exit. A tool that can only tell you what went up would never surface that sentence at all.*



This thing runs every weekday after the close and posts inside my [Swing Trading Desk](#). I'm going to show you how to read it, then how to build your own — and if by the end you'd rather just have mine every morning, that link works too. Read first.

## Part 1 — What skew actually is (in one page)

**The idea, before any jargon.** Insuring a house on a floodplain costs more than insuring the same house on a hill — the price of protection tells you something the house's value doesn't. Options are insurance on a stock, and the price of that insurance isn't symmetrical: protection against a fall usually costs more than a bet on a rise. Sometimes far more. Occasionally it flips entirely. **That gap, and which way it leans, is the whole signal.** Everything below is just how to measure it.

Now the mechanics. Every option on a stock has an implied volatility — the market's price for how much that stock might move. Here's the thing most people never notice: **those numbers aren't the same across strikes.**

Take any stock. Look at an out-of-the-money put and an out-of-the-money call that are equally unlikely to pay off — equally far out, opposite directions. On most equities, most of the time, the put is more expensive. That difference is **skew**. **The names where that flips are the entire reason this map exists.**

The shape of the measurement:



Skew = (OTM put IV – OTM call IV) ÷ ATM IV

**Positive** = puts cost more = protection is bid

**Negative** = calls cost more = upside is bid = someone is paying up to be long

*How far out those two strikes sit, and whether you divide by ATM at all, are decisions #1 and #3 in Part 4 — both worth settling deliberately rather than by default.*

Dividing by at-the-money IV is what makes a utility comparable to a semiconductor — it turns "puts are 4 vol points richer" into a percentage of that stock's own volatility.

Two things that matter more than the formula:

**Skew is positioning, not prediction.** It does not tell you where a stock is going. It tells you what people are paying to be positioned a certain way, which is a very different and much more honest thing. A name with heavy put skew isn't going down — it's a name where protection is expensive, which sometimes means everyone's already scared and sometimes means they're right.

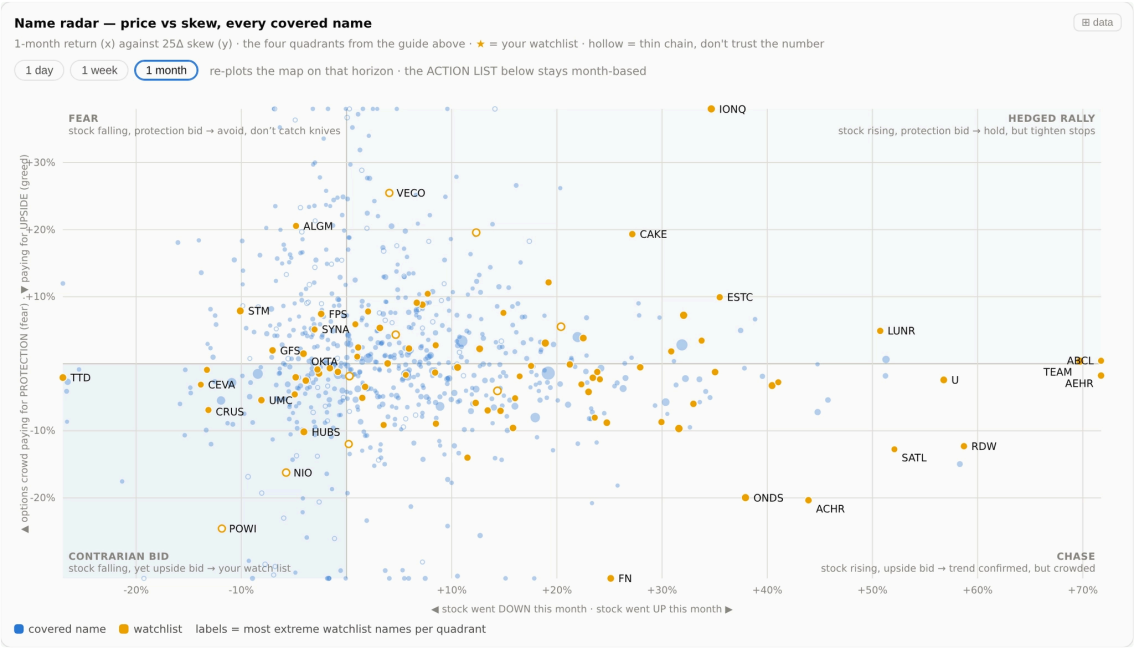
**The level is structural. The change is the signal.** Some names *always* carry put skew — that's just what that stock is. Comparing MU's skew to KO's skew tells you almost nothing. Comparing MU's skew today to MU's skew five days ago tells you a lot. This is the single biggest upgrade you can make to how you read it.

## Part 2 — The four quadrants

Here's where it becomes a map instead of a number. Put skew on one axis and the stock's one-month return on the other, and every name lands in one of four boxes. Each box means something specific.

| Quadrant                          | What it looks like                            | What it's telling you                                                                                     | My default action                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div></div> <b>CONTRARIAN BID</b> | Stock is DOWN on the month, but calls are bid | Price is falling while somebody is quietly paying up for upside. The tape and the options chain disagree. | <b>Watchlist.</b> This is the most interesting box on the map and reason I built it. |
| <div></div> <b>CHASE</b>          | Stock is UP, and calls are bid                | Everyone agrees. Price is up and people are still paying for more up.                                     | <b>Crowded.</b> Not wrong — just a worse entry than it was. Late, not bad.           |
| <div></div> <b>HEDGED RALLY</b>   | Stock is UP, but puts are bid                 | Price is rising and people are paying to protect against it reversing. The rally isn't trusted.           | <b>Tighten stops</b> on anything you already hold here.                              |
| <div></div> <b>FEAR</b>           | Stock is DOWN, and puts are bid               | Everyone agrees, in the other direction. Falling, and protection is getting more expensive.               | <b>Leave it alone.</b> Not a bargain. Not yet.                                       |

Here's what that looks like plotted on every name I cover:



Every dot is a stock; orange is my watchlist; hollow means a chain too thin to trust. The corner that earns its keep is bottom-left: names that fell on the month while somebody kept paying up for upside anyway. Top-right is the mirror image — rising, with protection being bought underneath. Neither is a signal on its own. Both are short lists you would never have assembled by scrolling a watchlist.

The same four boxes live inside the tool as a permanent explainer, because I got tired of re-deriving them:

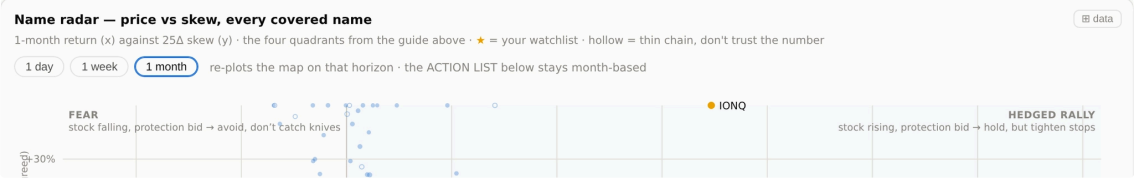
**How to read skew — the 30-second version**

Skew compares what traders pay for **puts** (protection against a drop) versus **calls** (a bet on a rally), both ~25Δ out. **Positive = puts cost more → paying for protection**  
**Negative = calls cost more → paying for upside**. The level alone is not a signal — low-vol names run positive naturally. What matters is skew **combined with price**, and how it **changes**:

| PRICE UP + CALLS BID                                                                                                                                                         | PRICE UP + PUTS BID                                                                                                                                                                | PRICE DOWN + CALLS BID                                                                                                                                                                                                     | PRICE DOWN + PUTS BID                                                                                                                              |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Chase</b><br>The crowd is paying up for more upside into strength. Trend confirmation — but upside options are expensive, and it's crowded. Stock > calls as the vehicle. | <b>Hedged rally</b><br>Price rising while protection gets bid. Someone big is hedging into strength — respect the trend, but tighten stops. Watch for this flip on names you hold. | <b>Contrarian bid</b><br>The interesting one. Price falling, yet someone is paying up for upside. Cheap stock AND cheap-ish upside options — the best asymmetry on the board when it's real. Check the quality flag first. | <b>Fear</b><br>Falling price, protection bid. The market believes the drop. Don't knife-catch; wait for skew to stop rising before bottom-fishing. |

The four verdicts, written down once so I never re-argue them at 4pm on a red day. If you build one thing off this page, build this card — deciding in advance what each box means is most of the discipline, and it's free.

One detail worth stealing: the map re-plots on three horizons, but the ranked list underneath stays anchored to one. A name that looks like a contrarian bid on the month and a chase on the day is telling you something — you just have to pick which clock is the official one.



Same names, three horizons. A stock that reads contrarian bid on the month but chase on the day is telling you the turn already started without you. Toggle the lens — but keep the verdict anchored to one clock, because changing both at once is how you talk yourself into anything.

The reason I care most about **contrarian bid** is that it's the only quadrant where two sources of information disagree. When price and positioning point the same way, you've learned nothing you couldn't get from a chart. When they split, something is happening that price hasn't shown you yet — sometimes it's an informed bid, sometimes it's a dated catalyst, and sometimes it's nothing. But it's the only box worth *investigating*, and that's what a research layer is for.

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## Part 3 — The five traps

This is the part I'd actually pay for, so it's the part I'm giving you first. Every one of these cost me something — either a rebuild, a day of debugging, or a read that was confidently wrong.

### 1. Never quote an index put/call ratio. Ever.

You've seen people post "SPY put/call is at X, the market is terrified." That number is not a sentiment reading. It's a **windowing decision** wearing a sentiment costume.

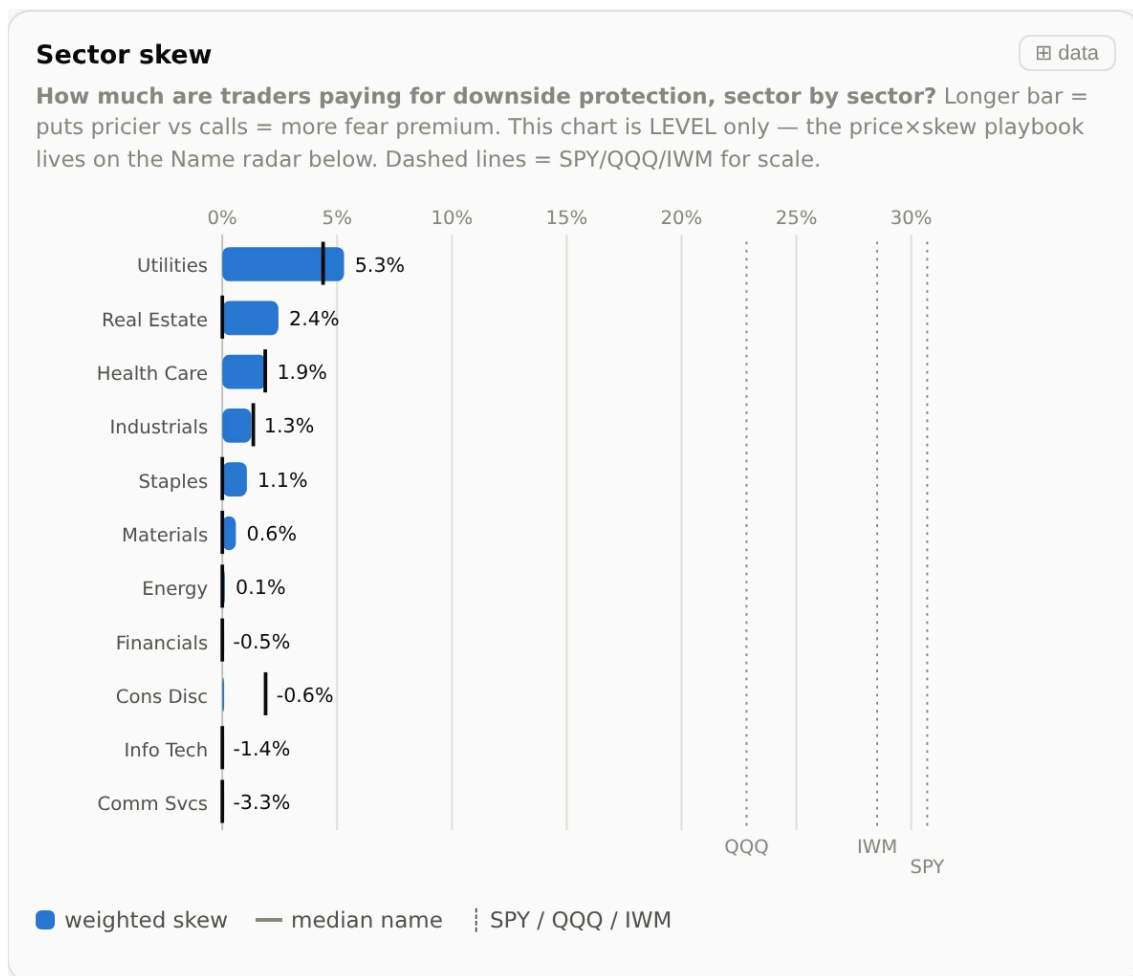
Here's why: about **86% of SPY put open interest sits below 0.10 delta** — lottery-ticket crash hedges nobody expects to pay off. So the number you get depends entirely on which strikes you decide to count. Measuring the whole chain, I get about **3.8**. Measuring a sane delta band, about **2**. I've seen a well-followed version of this tool publish **0.91** — and I swept twenty-four different windows trying to reproduce it and could not.

Same day. Same underlying. Three answers, one of which I still can't recreate. **Single-name and sector put/call are far less tail-dominated and stay usable. Index put/call is a coin flip with a decimal point.**

### 2. Don't compare sectors using normalized skew

Remember dividing by ATM IV? That's exactly right for comparing names *inside* a sector, and it quietly lies to you *across* sectors — because ATM IV varies by roughly 3x between Utilities and Semis. Divide by a small number and you get a big percentage.

Run that across the market and Utilities, Real Estate and Staples float to the top of your fear rankings basically every day, for arithmetic reasons. **For cross-sector comparison, use raw volatility points, not the normalized percentage.** Keep the normalized version for ranking names within a group, where it belongs.



Longer bar = puts pricier than calls = more fear premium sitting in that sector. The dashed lines are SPY, IWM and a third line, so you can see at a glance whether a sector carries more hedging than the index it lives inside. This chart is level only — and level on its own is never the trade, which is exactly why the map below crosses it with price.

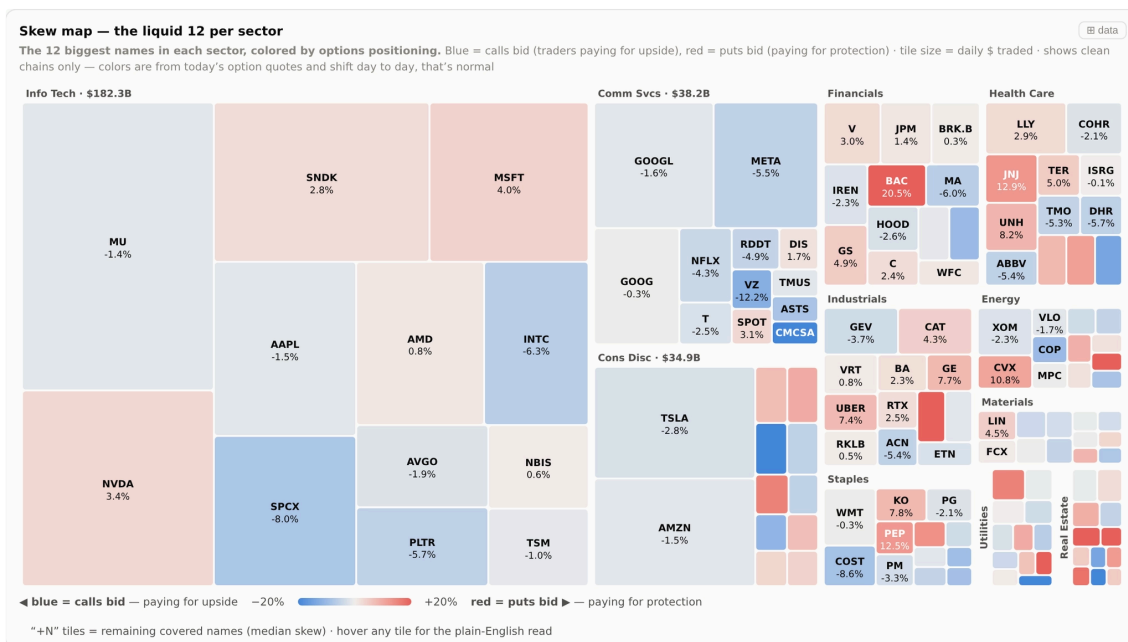
### 3. Check agreement before you trust any sector reading

A sector's skew is an average, and averages hide things. Before you say "energy is getting hedged," check what share of the names in that sector are actually leaning that way.

So pick an agreement threshold, and below it refuse to call it a sector move at all. Mine prints the agreement figure next to every sector row and auto-attaches a caveat when it's too low. Where exactly you set that line is a judgment call — the discipline that matters is setting it **once, in advance**, and never nudging it because a story you like is sitting just under it.

This is why I look at sectors as a grid of names rather than one number — you can see instantly whether a sector is leaning together or being dragged by two tiles:





Twelve biggest names per sector, colored by which side is bid, sized by dollars traded. The reason I look at a grid rather than a sector average: on most days the biggest tech names are split, some with puts bid and some with calls bid. "Tech is fearful" is almost always the wrong sentence, and the split is the actual information. One loud outlier tile is also exactly what drags a sector average when you haven't checked agreement first.

#### 4. One bad quote can invert an entire name

This is the embarrassing one. Early on, my system printed Duke Energy at a skew of  $-1.43$  — a screaming upside bid on a utility, which should have been my first clue. The truth was around  $+0.20$ . One bad option mark on one leg did it.

Worse: that single bad name dragged my whole validation correlation from  $0.90$  down to  $0.14$ . One number, and the entire map became untrustworthy — while still looking perfectly plausible.

So: **pick a sanity ceiling and hard-reject above it**. Decide the level at which you stop believing your own number and assume a bad mark — and set it by asking what's plausible for that kind of stock, not by looking at your data and drawing a line under the ugliest point. And if a name has a thin option chain — a handful of strikes, tiny open interest — treat every number it produces as noise, no matter how dramatic. Show it if you like, but label it and never act on it.

#### 5. A dated catalyst is not sentiment

If a name has earnings next week, the front-week options will be expensive. That's not fear — that's an event with a date on it, priced correctly.

Before reading any elevated skew as sentiment, **check the earnings calendar**. If there's a catalyst inside the expiry you're measuring, you're looking at event premium, not positioning. The tell is comparing the near-term expiry to the monthly: a big gap that collapses after the event was always just the event.

🧱 That's the read — the part that took me longest to learn and the part I'd have paid for. Everything below is construction.

**If you'd rather skip the construction:** this map lands in the Swing Trading Desk every trading day, already built and already read, alongside the weekly watchlist and every trade I take.

→ [See it inside the Desk](#)

## Part 4 — Build your own

No code, no API, no data subscription. Your broker's option chain, any free screener, and a spreadsheet.

🔧 **Build it on your own numbers.** Every decision below has a range of defensible answers, and the right one depends on your universe, your holding period, and how much noise you can stand.

This matters more than it sounds: **a number you didn't choose is a number you can't debug.** Mine once printed a utility at a screaming upside bid for days and looked beautiful doing it — I only caught it because I knew exactly what I'd set and why. Run settings you inherited from somebody else and the first time your board goes strange, you won't know which dial moved.

So below: the decision, why it matters, and what breaks if you get it wrong.

**First, the one piece of jargon.** Skew is measured between two strikes that are equally far out in *probability* terms. **Delta** is the industry's shorthand for that probability — an approximation rather than the exact number, but it's the one already printed on every chain you can open: Fidelity, Schwab, Robinhood, Webull, tastytrade, thinkorswim, all of them. A 25-delta option is loosely a 1-in-4 shot, and somewhere around there is the common convention. Which level you actually pick is decision #1 below.

**And the honest cost, up front:** an afternoon making these seven decisions, about an hour for your first pass, then 15–20 minutes a week. Six weeks before the change-based columns start meaning anything. Do it four times and you'll start recognizing names by their skew signature before you check the chart — which is the whole return on the exercise.

This version is free and it stays free. It also has a hard ceiling, and you'll hit it somewhere around week three. **I've written out exactly where it is at the bottom of this page** — go read that first if you'd rather know before you start than after.

## The seven decisions you have to make



| Decision                                                              | Why it matters                                                                                                 | What breaks if you get it wrong                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Which two strikes define your skew?                                | They have to be equidistant in probability, not in dollars or percent. Pick a delta level and hold it forever. | Use fixed percentage moneyness and a quiet stock and a violent one are no longer comparable — you'll rank volatility, not sentiment.                                                                                                     |
| 2. Which expiry — and is it fixed?                                    | You need one rule that picks the same <i>kind</i> of expiry every single run, for every name.                  | Let it drift and you're measuring the calendar. And outside the very largest names, weekly chains are too thin to trust — so mixing megacap weeklies with monthlies everywhere else means you're quietly comparing two different things. |
| 3. Do you normalize, or not?                                          | Raw difference and "divided by the stock's own volatility" are both valid. They answer different questions.    | Pick the wrong one for the comparison you're making and you get trap #2 — the same three sectors top your fear list every day for arithmetic reasons.                                                                                    |
| 4. What's your universe — and is your sector benchmark the same list? | It must not be. Your sector averages need their own broad, neutral universe.                                   | Benchmark against your own watchlist and every sector inherits your bias. Mine is roughly 60% semis and software; folding it in would make the whole market read like tech.                                                              |
| 5. What's your quality bar — and do you drop or down-weight?          | Some chains are too sparse to believe. You have to decide what happens to them.                                | Dropping is easy and throws away real information. Down-weighting is better and forces you to build a score. Doing neither means noise ranks alongside signal.                                                                           |
| 6. What's your sanity ceiling?                                        | Above some value you should stop believing your own number and assume a bad quote.                             | Set it by looking at your data and you'll draw the line under whatever's ugliest today. Set it by asking what's plausible for that kind of stock. See trap #4.                                                                           |
| 7. What do you store, and starting when?                              | Every change-based reading needs history you don't have on day one.                                            | Skip this and in six weeks you'll still be reading levels instead of changes — which is the reading that actually matters.                                                                                                               |

## The weekly loop

1. **Pick your universe.** 15 to 25 names you already follow. These are the names you're going to *rank*.

Then pick a second, broader list you did not choose — a sector ETF's holdings page is free and neutral. That one is your sector *benchmark*, per decision #4. Ranking your own picks against your own picks tells you nothing; it just launders your existing bias back to you as a signal. Decide your own minimum names-per-sector before a sector read counts, and write it at the top of the sheet.

2. **Apply your expiry rule** (decision #2) and use it for every name without exception. Monthlies, roughly a month or two out, is the sane neighbourhood; the exact window is yours. Same rule every week or nothing is comparable to anything.
3. **Pull three numbers per name** from that chain: at-the-money IV, plus the put IV and call IV at your chosen delta (decision #1), mirrored either side.
4. **Compute skew**: put IV against call IV, normalized however you settled decision #3.
5. **Add price context**: the stock's 1-month % return. Also compute that return **minus SPY's** — plot the raw return on the map (that's what mine does) and keep the vs-SPY number in a column next to it, because everything looks strong in a strong month.
6. **Add volume context**: today's volume ÷ its average volume. Free on any screener. Set your own heavy/light cutoffs — pick them once, write them at the top of the sheet, and don't move them mid-week.
7. **Plot it**. Scatter chart, x-axis = 1-month return, y-axis = skew. You now have the four quadrants from Part 2, with your names sitting in them.

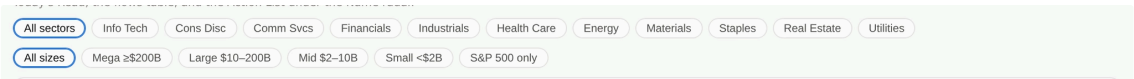
**Expect it to look lopsided, and don't assume you broke it.** Positive put skew is the resting state for most equities, so if you crosshair at zero, the majority of your names will pile into the top half and the two negative-skew boxes will look almost empty. That's not a bug — that's *why* those two boxes are the interesting ones and why they're never crowded. If you'd rather have a genuinely centred map, put the crosshair on the median of your own list instead of at zero. Either is defensible. Just write down which one you chose, because the two maps say different things.

8. **Save the file with the date**. This is the step everyone skips and it's the one that makes the whole thing work — because next week you can compute the **change** — and as Part 1 says, the level is structural but the change is the actual signal. Six weeks in, you'll have something genuinely rare.
9. **When you outgrow the sheet, connect it to institutional data**. Hand-entry caps you at roughly twenty names, once a week. Going past that means pulling chains and price history programmatically, which needs a plan on the stock side and a plan on the options side — around \$30 a month each. The options side is the one that matters: it has to carry per-contract implied volatility and greeks, not just prices. That's the unlock, and it's the moment this stops being a spreadsheet and starts being a system.

## The sheet

| Column         | What goes in it                                                                                        | Source           |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Ticker         | Your 15–25 names                                                                                       | You              |
| Sector         | Group label                                                                                            | You              |
| ATM IV         | IV at the money, on your chosen expiry                                                                 | Broker chain     |
| Put IV         | IV at your chosen put delta, same expiry                                                               | Broker chain     |
| Call IV        | IV at the mirror-image call delta, same expiry                                                         | Broker chain     |
| Skew           | Put IV against call IV, normalized however you settled decision #3                                     | Your formula     |
| Vol points     | The un-normalized version. Keep both columns — this is the one that survives a cross-sector comparison | Your formula     |
| 1M return      | Stock's 1-month % change                                                                               | Any screener     |
| 1M vs SPY      | <code>=Stock1M - SPY1M</code>                                                                          | Formula          |
| RVOL           | <code>=TodayVol / AvgVol</code>                                                                        | Any screener     |
| Earnings date  | Next confirmed date — trap #5                                                                          | Any calendar     |
| Chain OK?      | Yes/No — thin chain = ignore the number                                                                | Your eyes        |
| Sector rank    | Where this name's skew sits inside its own sector group — the sentence in Part 5 needs it              | Your formula     |
| Δ vs last week | <code>=ThisWeekSkew - LastWeekSkew</code>                                                              | Last week's file |

One upgrade once the sheet works: make it **sliceable**. Being able to cut the same board by sector and by size is what turns a list into a tool — "is this a tech thing or a small-cap thing" is a question you'll ask constantly, and it should take one click, not a rebuild.



*The same board, sliced. "Is this a tech story or a small-cap story?" is a question you'll ask constantly, and it should cost one click rather than a rebuild. In a spreadsheet this is just a filter row — but decide up front that every view is sliceable, because retrofitting it later is miserable.*

## Part 5 — Reading a row out loud

I force every name through the same sentence, in the same order, every single day. Not because it's elegant — because a fixed template stops me from telling myself a story about the ones I already like.

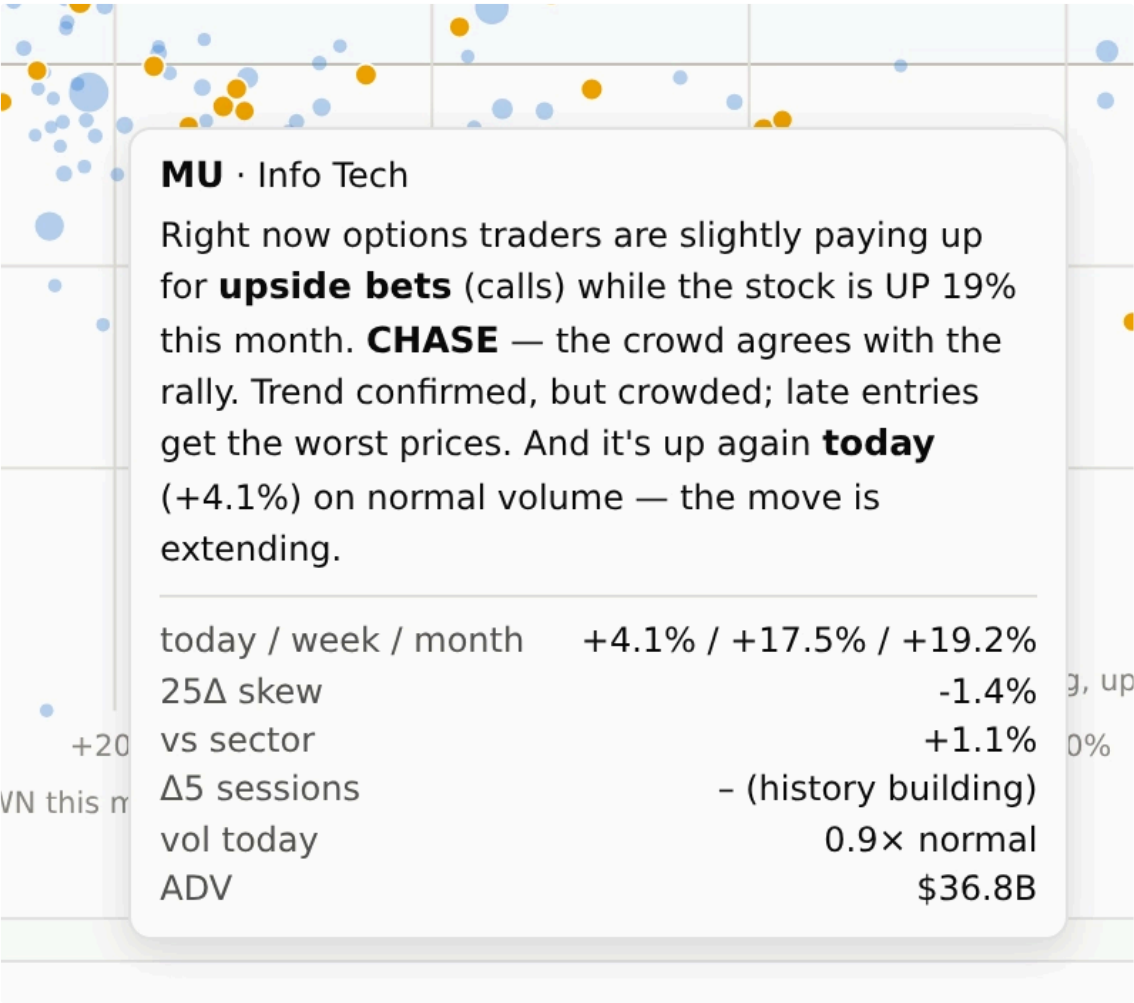
 [Ticker] — traders are paying [slightly / clearly / heavily] more for [puts / calls], which is more [fear / upside] than [X%] of its sector. The stock is [up/down X%] on the month [vs SPY], on [heavy / normal / light] volume. That puts it in [quadrant].

Here's mine writing that sentence by itself — this is a real row from August 17, hovered:

|       |           |         |       |       |        |        |          |                                                                                                                                                               |     |      |       |   |      |    |
|-------|-----------|---------|-------|-------|--------|--------|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|------|-------|---|------|----|
| NVDA  | Info Tech | 225.01  | 5,268 | -0.1% | +3.4%  | +10.9% | 24,970.1 | 0.8×                                                                                                                                                          | 38% | 3.4% | +5.9% | - | 0.64 | ok |
| SNDK  | Info Tech | 1786.85 | 186   | +8.9% | +44.3% | +31.9% | 22,864.1 | 1.4×                                                                                                                                                          | 86% | 2.8% | +5.4% | - | 1.35 | ok |
| MSFT  | Info Tech | 480.35  | 3,741 | -3.0% | -5.1%  | +22.0% | 16       | SNDK · Info Tech · \$1786.85                                                                                                                                  |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| AAPL  | Info Tech | 305.59  | 4,450 | -0.1% | -0.9%  | -8.4%  | 16       | Right now options traders are slightly paying up for <b>downside protection</b> (puts) while the stock is UP 32% this month. <b>HEDGED RALLY</b> —            |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| SPCX  | Info Tech | 146.23  | 1,927 | +4.5% | +5.4%  | +17.9% | 16       | someone big is buying insurance into strength. If you hold it, tighten your stops. More fear priced in than 82% of its sector. And it's up again <b>today</b> |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| AMD   | Info Tech | 506     | 774   | -1.6% | +7.8%  | +2.1%  | 13       | (+8.9%) on <b>1.4× normal volume</b> — real conviction — the move is extending.                                                                               |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| TSLA  | Cons Disc | 339.3   | 1,314 | -0.9% | +2.5%  | -10.9% | 12       | today / week / month +8.9% / +44.3% / +31.9%                                                                                                                  |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| AMZN  | Cons Disc | 261.31  | 2,937 | -0.5% | -6.0%  | +5.7%  | 12       | vol today 1.4× normal                                                                                                                                         |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| INTC  | Info Tech | 103.49  | 493   | +1.0% | +6.1%  | +8.9%  | 11       | 25Δ skew 2.8%                                                                                                                                                 |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| GOOGL | Comm Svcs | 344     | 4,205 | -0.5% | -3.8%  | -0.8%  | 10       | vs sector +5.4%                                                                                                                                               |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| META  | Comm Svcs | 568.97  | 1,526 | -3.5% | -4.4%  | -11.9% | 9        | — — unlocks in 2 more trading days                                                                                                                            |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| AVGO  | Info Tech | 392.43  | 1,980 | -0.1% | -7.1%  | +5.8%  | 7        | Δ5d shift 1.35                                                                                                                                                |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| GOOG  | Comm Svcs | 341.45  | 4,195 | -0.6% | -4.0%  | -1.4%  | 7        | P/C OI ok                                                                                                                                                     |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| PLTR  | Info Tech | 172.55  | 420   | -0.9% | -1.5%  | +30.3% | 6        | quality                                                                                                                                                       |     |      |       |   |      |    |
| NBIS  | Info Tech | 268.85  | 49.1  | -3.2% | +46.0% | +51.3% | 5,569.5  | 0.9×                                                                                                                                                          | 99% | 0.6% | +3.2% | - | 1.65 | ok |

Read it against the template above, in order: what they're paying for → how that ranks inside its own sector → price context → volume → verdict. The pattern this one catches: a stock up hard on the month with the put side still bid, carrying more fear premium than most of its sector. That is not a top call. It reads as someone insuring a winner they intend to keep — which is a tighten-your-stop signal rather than an exit signal, and those two get confused constantly.

And the same sentence follows the name everywhere — here it is again off a dot on the map instead of a row in the table:



Same sentence, different surface — a dot on the map instead of a row in the table. The consistency matters more than any individual number here: it means I can't accidentally tell myself two different stories about the same stock depending on where I happened to click. Whatever the read is, it follows the name everywhere.

You can write that sentence by hand from your spreadsheet in about fifteen seconds a name. That's the point — the automation isn't the insight, the sentence is.

Two rules on that sentence. **Say the quadrant out loud** — it forces a verdict instead of a vibe. And **end with the action**, which for a skew map is almost always "watchlist" or "leave it," because this layer tells you *where to look* and it is structurally incapable of telling you when.

► Part 6 — If you're going to automate it, read this first

 **Should you automate it?** Open Part 6 above for the honest answer: eight failure modes that never throw an error, and the only reliable way to catch them is building the whole thing twice and diffing the output every day. I did it because I wanted to know exactly how every number on my screen was made. That's a real reason — it just isn't a good enough reason for most people.

If you'd rather skip to the part that pays: I post this map every trading day inside the Swing Trading Desk, already built and already read.

→ [See the daily map inside the Desk](#)

## Part 7 — Where skew stops and the rest of the board starts

Skew answers one question: what are people paying to be positioned. It cannot tell you where the money is actually *moving*. Those are different signals and they're at their most useful when they disagree — so on my board the skew map sits alongside a flow layer.

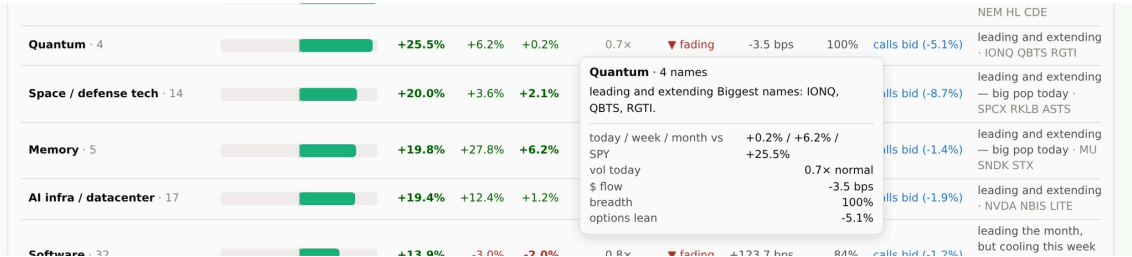
Money flow by industry, ranked, with a plain verdict on each row:

| Theme                         | 1M vs SPY ↓            | 1M rel ↓ | 1W rel | Today | Vol today | Trend now   | \$ flow    | Breadth | Options lean      | Plain-English read ↓                                                       |
|-------------------------------|------------------------|----------|--------|-------|-----------|-------------|------------|---------|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gold / silver miners · 18     | <div><div></div></div> | +27.3%   | +3.4%  | +2.6% | 1.0×      | ▼ fading    | +9.4 bps   | 100%    | calls bid (-1.8%) | leading and extending — big pop today · NEM HL CDE                         |
| Quantum · 4                   | <div><div></div></div> | +25.5%   | +6.2%  | +0.2% | 0.7×      | ▼ fading    | -3.5 bps   | 100%    | calls bid (-5.1%) | leading and extending · IONQ QBTS RGTI                                     |
| Space / defense tech · 14     | <div><div></div></div> | +20.0%   | +3.6%  | +2.1% | 1.1×      | ▼ fading    | -7 bps     | 93%     | calls bid (-8.7%) | leading and extending — big pop today · SPCX RKL B ASTS                    |
| Memory · 5                    | <div><div></div></div> | +19.8%   | +27.8% | +6.2% | 1.1×      | ▲ improving | -98.6 bps  | 100%    | calls bid (-1.4%) | leading and extending — big pop today · MU SNDK STX                        |
| AI infra / datacenter · 17    | <div><div></div></div> | +19.4%   | +12.4% | +1.2% | 1.0×      | ▲ improving | +39.4 bps  | 100%    | calls bid (-1.9%) | leading and extending · NVDA NBIS LITE                                     |
| Software · 32                 | <div><div></div></div> | +13.9%   | -3.0%  | -2.0% | 0.8×      | ▼ fading    | +123.7 bps | 84%     | calls bid (-1.2%) | leading the month, but cooling this week — hit hard today · MSFT PLTR ORCL |
| Nuclear / uranium · 10        | <div><div></div></div> | +9.9%    | +0.2%  | -0.5% | 0.9×      | ▼ fading    | -0.2 bps   | 100%    | calls bid (-3.1%) | leading and extending · OKLO CCJ SMR                                       |
| Oil & gas · 17                | <div><div></div></div> | +6.3%    | +4.3%  | +1.6% | 1.0×      | ▲ improving | +12.8 bps  | 100%    | neutral (-0.9%)   | leading and extending — big pop today · XOM CVX VLO                        |
| Defense primes · 8            | <div><div></div></div> | +5.8%    | -1.2%  | -1.2% | 1.0×      | ▼ fading    | +7.1 bps   | 75%     | puts bid (2.5%)   | leading the month, but cooling this week · RTX LMT HWM                     |
| Crypto miners / treasury · 14 | <div><div></div></div> | +5.0%    | +7.0%  | +3.8% | 1.0×      | ▲ improving | +5.2 bps   | 43%     | calls bid (-2.3%) | leading, but few names carrying it — big pop today · IREN MSTR CIBR        |
| Semi equipment · 16           | <div><div></div></div> | +4.5%    | +9.7%  | +4.2% | 1.0×      | ▲ improving | -77.5 bps  | 94%     | calls bid (-1.7%) | leading and extending — big pop today · AMAT LRCX ASML                     |
| Biotech · 19                  | <div><div></div></div> | +4.3%    | +2.1%  | +2.0% | 0.9×      | ▲ improving | +2.4 bps   | 74%     | puts bid (2.0%)   | leading and extending — big pop today · AMGN GILD VRTX                     |
| Travel / leisure · 16         | <div><div></div></div> | +4.0%    | -0.6%  | -1.9% | 0.9×      | ▼ fading    | +6 bps     | 44%     | puts bid (4.2%)   | leading the month, but cooling this week — hit hard today · BKNG ABNB HLT  |
| Semiconductors · 30           | <div><div></div></div> | +3.0%    | +4.2%  | +1.1% | 0.9×      | ▲ improving | -218.5 bps | 87%     | neutral (0.0%)    | leading and extending · NVDA AMD INTC                                      |
| Power / grid · 9              | <div><div></div></div> | +1.3%    | +6.9%  | +1.3% | 0.8×      | ▲ improving | +0.1 bps   | 67%     | neutral (0.0%)    | tracking the market · BE GEV ETN                                           |
| Cybersecurity · 11            | <div><div></div></div> | +0.9%    | -3.0%  | -1.6% | 1.0×      | ▼ fading    | -1.6 bps   | 64%     | neutral (-0.5%)   | tracking the market — hit hard today · PANW                                |

Sorted by one-month return against SPY, with a participation column beside it — a theme leading on 100% of its names is the healthy kind of move, one leading on a third of them is two stocks wearing a costume. The comparison that pays is monthly against weekly: when a theme's whole month happened in the last five days, that's a different situation from one that's been grinding, even though the month column looks identical.

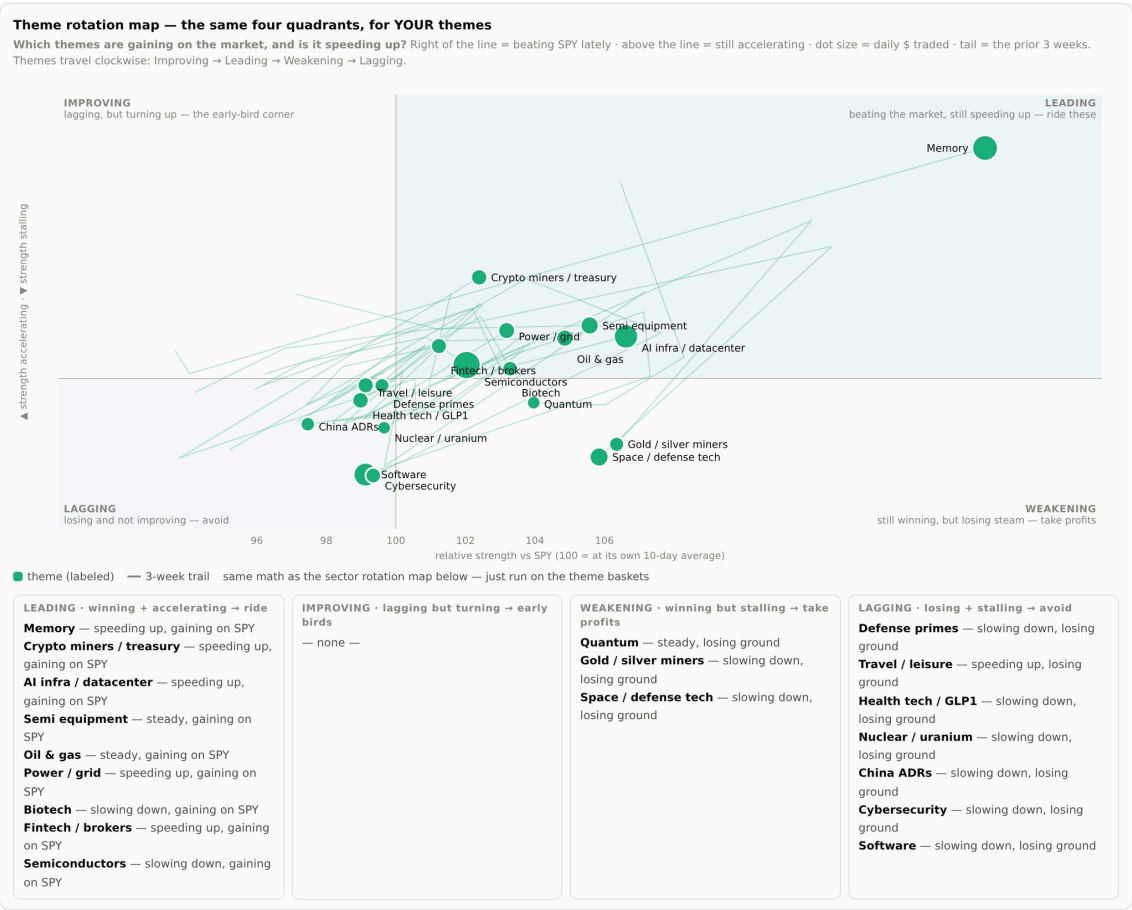


Every row explains itself the same way the names do:



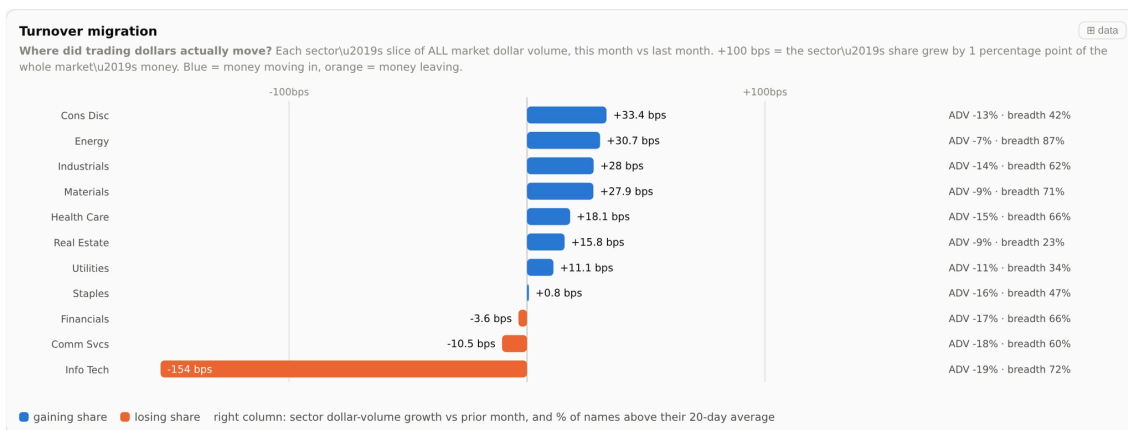
Hovering any theme gives the read plus the biggest names inside it — so a line like "this theme is leading and extending" resolves immediately into three tickers you can actually go look at. That's the step most dashboards skip, and it's the one that matters: a theme you can't convert into names isn't a signal, it's a headline.

The same four-quadrant idea, applied to themes instead of individual names:



The same four quadrants, run on themes instead of individual names. Right of the line = beating SPY; above it = still accelerating; the tail behind each dot is the last three weeks, so you see direction rather than just position. Themes travel clockwise — Improving → Leading → Weakening → Lagging. The quadrant nobody respects is Weakening — still winning, quietly losing steam. That's the one people add to, because the month-to-date number still looks great.

And where the money physically went, week over week:



Where the dollars actually went, this month against last. The column that stops you making a mistake is breadth, on the right: a sector can gain share of the market's entire volume while only a fifth of its names participate — which is one or two stocks, not a rotation. Share moved plus breadth thin is a headline. Share moved plus breadth broad is a trend.

You do not need any of this to start. It's here so you know what the spreadsheet grows into, and so you can decide which layer is worth your Sunday.

## How I'd actually use this

A skew map is a **where-to-look layer**. That's the whole job. It is not a buy list, it does not produce entries, and the fastest way to lose money with it is to treat a quadrant as a signal.

Here's how the four buckets actually change my week:

- **Contrarian bid** → these go on the watchlist. Not bought — *watched*. Then I pull up the chart and start asking the questions this layer can't answer.
- **Chase** → I already know about these, everyone does. If I don't own it, I'm late; the map's job here is to stop me from feeling clever about a crowded trade.
- **Hedged rally** → about things I already own. Rally the options market doesn't trust, so I tighten.
- **Fear** → nothing. Cheap and falling with protection getting *more* expensive is not a bargain.

Once you've got the map, the last step is ranking — which of the interesting names is *most* interesting today:

**Most asymmetric positioning first.** The rank rewards names that already fell hard while the options crowd leans BULLISH vs their sector peers — the market's "this is done falling" tell — plus a bonus when today bounced on real volume. Same deterministic formula every day, top 15 shown. Hover any row for the full plain-English read. ★ = your watchlist.

| Name  | What to do                  | Asym ↓ | Px      | 1D    | 1W     | 1M     | Vol  | Skew   | vs sector | Δ5d | Read ↓                                                      |
|-------|-----------------------------|--------|---------|-------|--------|--------|------|--------|-----------|-----|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| FTV   | FRESH LOOK — contrarian bid | 191    | 60.64   | -1.6% | -1.8%  | -1.8%  | 0.6× | -84.6% | -86.5%    | -   | fell 2% in a month · calls bid vs peers                     |
| HBAN  | FRESH LOOK — contrarian bid | 178    | 17.95   | +0.2% | +2.0%  | -1.6%  | 0.9× | -80.7% | -80.6%    | -   | fell 2% in a month · calls bid vs peers                     |
| SUI   | FRESH LOOK — contrarian bid | 165    | 121.36  | -1.6% | +2.4%  | -0.1%  | 1.4× | -74.3% | -73.6%    | -   | fell 0% in a month · calls bid vs peers · 1.4× volume today |
| FDX   | MOMENTUM — crowded          | 162    | 331.49  | -0.9% | +2.0%  | +5.9%  | 1.0× | -72.4% | -73.8%    | -   | up 6% in a month · calls bid vs peers                       |
| WY    | FRESH LOOK — contrarian bid | 128    | 24.08   | -1.9% | -4.8%  | -1.7%  | 0.9× | -58.5% | -57.8%    | -   | fell 2% in a month · calls bid vs peers                     |
| SPGI  | FRESH LOOK — contrarian bid | 121    | 410.53  | -2.0% | -0.1%  | -8.9%  | 0.7× | -52.8% | -52.8%    | -   | fell 9% in a month · calls bid vs peers                     |
| JHX   | MOMENTUM — crowded          | 100    | 30.43   | -2.0% | 0.0%   | +17.8% | 0.8× | -46.0% | -45.6%    | -   | up 18% in a month · calls bid vs peers                      |
| BDX   | MOMENTUM — crowded          | 96     | 182.09  | -0.7% | +1.4%  | +15.1% | 0.8× | -41.8% | -43.6%    | -   | up 15% in a month · calls bid vs peers                      |
| FN ★  | MOMENTUM — crowded          | 88     | 598.58  | +5.0% | +13.6% | +25.1% | 2.3× | -41.0% | -38.5%    | -   | up 25% in a month · calls bid vs peers · 2.3× volume today  |
| ITW   | MOMENTUM — crowded          | 83     | 287.28  | -1.2% | -2.5%  | +4.1%  | 0.7× | -36.2% | -37.6%    | -   | up 4% in a month · calls bid vs peers                       |
| AWK   | FRESH LOOK — contrarian bid | 78     | 134.35  | -1.4% | -0.8%  | -0.6%  | 0.9× | -30.8% | -35.2%    | -   | fell 1% in a month · calls bid vs peers                     |
| CMCSA | MOMENTUM — crowded          | 77     | 25.57   | -2.3% | +1.5%  | +7.5%  | 0.7× | -36.6% | -35.0%    | -   | up 7% in a month · calls bid vs peers                       |
| PH    | MOMENTUM — crowded          | 73     | 1053.76 | -0.2% | -0.6%  | +10.5% | 1.0× | -31.7% | -33.0%    | -   | up 11% in a month · calls bid vs peers                      |
| FANG  | MOMENTUM — crowded          | 72     | 206.29  | +1.9% | +3.7%  | +5.5%  | 0.7× | -34.2% | -32.5%    | -   | up 6% in a month · calls bid vs peers                       |
| PCAR  | MOMENTUM — crowded          | 71     | 130.84  | +0.0% | -0.3%  | +3.7%  | 0.6× | -30.8% | -32.2%    | -   | up 4% in a month · calls bid vs peers                       |

Asym = asymmetry rank, higher = more interesting (it is positioning, not prediction) names ranked here still need YOUR chart, zone and risk work before they're trades

The ranked shortlist, and the reason the verdict column exists. Two rows can carry the identical signal — the options crowd leaning bullish against their sector peers — and mean opposite things: on a name that already fell, it reads FRESH LOOK, contrarian bid; on a name that already ran, it reads MOMENTUM, crowded. Same evidence, different verdict, decided by where price already is. The footer says the quiet part out loud: these still need your chart, your zone and your risk before any of them is a trade.

And then the honest part: the map hands you a shortlist, and a shortlist is not a trade. It tells you a name is interesting today. It cannot tell you the level to watch, where the idea is wrong, or whether today is the day. Those come off the chart, and they're a completely separate skill.

That gap is where people lose money on genuinely good ideas. You can be right about which name and still lose, because you were wrong about where and when.

## The whole point: every name gets a bucket

Here's what I actually want you to take away. It isn't any single number on this page — it's that nothing is left unclassified.

Universe ranked by 21-day average daily dollar volume (\$724.5B total). Skew computed for 777 of 550 targeted names (top 50 per sector). Missing from chains: ADC, AHR, AROC, CTRE, CZR, DOC, ELS, HLN, KIM, MKTX, NI, NVR, NWS, NWSA, REXR, ROL. 8 small names unclassified. Built 2026-08-17.

777 names with skew computed, ranked by 21-day average dollar volume — \$724.5B of it — and the sixteen that failed a chain check are named individually rather than quietly dropped. That last part is the tell for whether any dataset is honest: a system that hides what it couldn't cover is hiding the size of its own blind spot.

Every one of those names comes out the other side wearing a verdict. Contrarian bid — falling, but someone's paying for upside, so it goes on the watchlist. Crowded — working, everyone knows, so don't chase it. Hedged rally — tighten. Fear — leave it. Look back at the action board above: every row carries its label in plain English, in the same words every single day.

That's the difference between having a tool and having an opinion. When you open a board where all several hundred names are already sorted, you're not hunting for something interesting — you're choosing between things that have already been filtered, with the reasoning attached. And on the days nothing is interesting, it tells you that too, which is the part that saves the most money.

Underneath it all sits the full database — every covered name, every column, sortable:

| Ticker | Sector    | Price   | MCap \$B | 1D    | 1W     | 1M     | ADV \$M ↓ | Vol  | ATM IV | 25Δ skew | vs sector | Δ5d skew | P/C OI | Qual |
|--------|-----------|---------|----------|-------|--------|--------|-----------|------|--------|----------|-----------|----------|--------|------|
| MU     | Info Tech | 1011.75 | 981      | +4.1% | +17.5% | +19.2% | 36,758.2  | 0.9× | 65%    | -1.4%    | +1.1%     | -        | 0.69   | ok   |
| NVDA   | Info Tech | 225.01  | 5,268    | -0.1% | +3.4%  | +10.9% | 24,970.1  | 0.8× | 38%    | 3.4%     | +5.9%     | -        | 0.64   | ok   |
| SNDK   | Info Tech | 1786.85 | 186      | +8.9% | +44.3% | +31.9% | 22,864.1  | 1.4× | 86%    | 2.8%     | +5.4%     | -        | 1.35   | ok   |
| MSFT   | Info Tech | 480.35  | 3,741    | -3.0% | -5.1%  | +22.0% | 16,859.8  | 0.8× | 26%    | 4.0%     | +6.5%     | -        | 0.42   | ok   |
| AAPL   | Info Tech | 305.59  | 4,450    | -0.1% | -0.9%  | -8.4%  | 16,486.4  | 0.7× | 24%    | -1.5%    | +1.0%     | -        | 0.62   | ok   |
| SPCX   | Info Tech | 146.23  | 1,927    | +4.5% | +5.4%  | +17.9% | 14,212    | 1.2× | 65%    | -8.0%    | -5.5%     | -        | 0.76   | ok   |
| AMD    | Info Tech | 506     | 774      | -1.6% | +7.8%  | +2.1%  | 13,888.8  | 0.7× | 54%    | 0.8%     | +3.4%     | -        | 0.78   | ok   |
| TSLA   | Cons Disc | 339.3   | 1,314    | -0.9% | +2.5%  | -10.9% | 12,808.4  | 0.7× | 39%    | -2.8%    | -4.7%     | -        | 1.20   | ok   |
| AMZN   | Cons Disc | 261.31  | 2,937    | -0.5% | -6.0%  | +5.7%  | 12,326.1  | 0.9× | 28%    | -1.5%    | -3.4%     | -        | 0.51   | ok   |